

process does not have to be a nightmare, and any salesperson who is being rude to you is not worth your time.

Lack of clarity or transparency. If a dealership cannot answer all your questions in great detail, that is a bad sign. If they are vague on the details of the car's history or the exact price they are going to give you, it's probably because they know you would be less likely to buy it if you knew the answer.

Skipping the test drive and mechanic's inspection. Do not buy any car without driving it first. A test drive may reveal big problems, like a muffler falling off, but more practically it will tell you whether or not you enjoy driving the car. Also, because most of us know very little about cars, be sure you take it to a mechanic for inspection regardless of how great it feels during the test drive.

Do I Really Need a Car?

Another option worth considering is whether or not you need a car at all. Today, with many alternative forms of ridesharing and transportation like Uber, Lyft, Zipcar, and sweet scooters and bikes you can rent with apps, owning a car is not as essential as it used to be. This can be especially true if you live in a larger city.

Like any financial decision, you need to weigh the pros and cons of owning a car to make the right choice. If you live in a city that has decent public transportation, that may be a good option for you. If you work from home and don't participate in activities that require a ton of driving, using Uber or another form of transportation may be cheaper than paying for your car, insurance, gas, and maintenance every month.